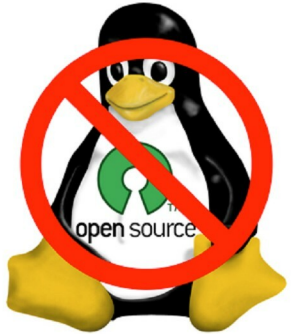


West Bengal Government Turns Anti-Open Source



West Bengal is facing a problem similar to what Tamil Nadu faced a few months back— anti-open source government policies.

The West Bengal information technology (IT) minister recently urged global IT software giant Microsoft to invest in Bengal, promising all assistance by way of infrastructure and encouragement from the government's side. And it went on to sign an MOU with Microsoft, according to which the company will invest in West Bengal if the government of West Bengal vetoes anything apart from the use of Microsoft's cloud platform and technology for future e-governance projects.

A state that has been known as one of the front-runners in FOSS adoption has now entered into a conditional pact, where it has 'willingly' chosen to spend money on proprietary software despite the availability of free and open source alternatives. The state government floated a tender for the West Bengal Pollution Control Board (WBPCB), where it invited the 'Bidding Document for Supply and Installation of Microsoft Windows Operating System and Anti-virus Software.'

According to the tender, the bidders are required to install Microsoft Windows Operating System 7, Microsoft Office (supplied by the WBPCB) and Quick Heal Total Security Anti-virus 2011 on the computer systems of the end users, and transfer legacy data to the newly transformed environment.

At a stage where even the central government is exploring options to use FOSS in e-governance projects, the West Bengal government, which was earlier pro-open source, is moving backwards. It is worth mentioning here that in the WBPCB, not only was GNU/Linux adopted extensively, but even in-house expertise was in place to support and develop FOSS/OSS. Systems like the Environment Management Information System had already been developed.

West Bengal has always shown a fondness for FOSS. The WB IOTA (Institute of Open Technology and Applications) was set up as an autonomous body, with funding from the IT Department. IOTA's charter includes the promotion of FOSS in government and academia, and it was founded in 2007. Its aim was also to help in the general plan of "...getting the support infrastructure for FOSS/OSS adoption" in all government departments and educational institutions. This was in line with the recommendations of a certain section of advisers, OSS service providers and others to "develop the support infrastructure first." IOTA achieved a lot in popularising FOSS/OSS—publishing books, and organising a number of training programmes and seminars/workshops on FOSS awareness, e-governance and adoption.

But it seems that things changed with the government. That is why the community, i.e., the Kolkata chapter of the Indian GNU/Linux User Group (GLUG) has taken the initiative to file a petition against such moves.

The background note (preamble) of the petition says, "We, the members of the Kolkata Chapter of the Indian GNU/Linux User Group (<http://www.ilug-cal.info>), Free Software Mancha of West Bengal (<http://www.fsmwb.org>) and FOSS (Free and Open Source Software) activists across the country have been observing a marked shift towards the adoption of closed source proprietary software by the present government of West Bengal. This is a retrograde trend that is bound to adversely affect earlier efforts towards the adoption of FOSS in e-governance (at least in some sectors), education, and other sectors, by the previous government, and any concept of freedom that the people of